

Take it or leave it

I'm now officially ancient (and the team never fails to remind me of that). This month I completed a decade of working for my favourite magazine, and I can vouch for the truth of the statement, "time flies when you're having fun". However, what has struck me the most over the past decade is how much less fun I've been having as the years progress. No, this is not a rant aimed at my bosses, this is a rant aimed at the technology makers, Microsoft and Apple maybe, Sony especially!

I'm often called a fossil for preferring my powerful desktops over laptops and tablets, and certainly also the phones or phablets out there. Sure they have their uses, but none of them is a serious creation tool; they're just fountains of data for the ravenous consumers of content.

The statement of having less fun is to do with the death of the tinkerer, the killing off of curiosity, the maiming of the spirit to discover. There was a time when all of us who worked at Digit and those of us who read it would be called "geeks", and it was a badge we'd proudly wear. We didn't need to be Electronics engineers to pull out a soldering iron, or take a Metal Works course before dremelling our cabinets into new shapes, or get certified before dabbling in code to try and tweak something. Linux was loved because of this very reason: it taught you to think, to experiment, to try – and most importantly, it taught you to fail...

Linux isn't popular anymore, and neither is any of the rest in most cases. No one's teaching anyone how to fail, how to get back up afterwards, how to try anything new... how to be a geek, basically. There's an app for everything; there's no reason for you and me to know how to do anything more than work a few buttons. There's no glory or sense of pride in anything that doesn't make you rich – no one wants to start another Wikipedia, everyone wants to start another Facebook.

I'm sure there are enough Digit readers out there who will disagree, and I'm thankful that they do, or else we ourselves wouldn't exist ... but this isn't really about you, the person holding this magazine. This is about the world around you, the people you're sitting next to while reading, your co-workers, your kids, siblings, parents even.

Apple made "easy" popular, and everyone else is playing catch-up in a mindless stampede. Sony took away the ability to install Linux on my PS3 a few years ago, plays Big Brother with DRM techniques such as Cinavia, and thanks to the Blu-ray market in India being largely unorganised and unregulated, I can't seem to find any good movies to watch that also happen to be from my "region". Completely following the letter of the law of course, but how come all other Blu-ray players seem to magically transform into "region-free" players when you enter a silly code?

Microsoft, on the other hand, has ensured that I will use nothing other than Windows 7 on any desktop, because that tile interface of Windows 8 is terrible for anyone using a keyboard and mouse, and not wanting to check Facebook updates every 2.63 seconds. Sadly, I'm a dwindling minority, and I suspect you are too.

There's just no room left for tinkering, to have fun, to unlock and fool about. If the powers that be get their way, we're moving into completely closed platforms, with even more ridiculous ploys. For example, in the US, the copyrights office is removing the exemption that was given thus far to unlocking your mobile phone. I'm not saying carriers are going to start suing individuals for unlocking phones, but it certainly won't be as easy as before to have a phone unlocked, and yes, you will be breaking a US law!

So is this the future? Take it or leave it, but don't try to change, improve or customise it? Instead of building intelligent communities and crowdsourcing to make things better and more customisable like Open Source did, are we headed into the building up of even more grey market dealers operating from shady offices offering to unlock your phone, or change your iPad battery, or just do the fun stuff that you'd much rather do yourself? 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

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